

THINK COLLEGE NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER

Annual Report on the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities

Executive Summary for Years 1 & 2 (FY11, FY12)



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Institute for Community Inclusion
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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Higher education leads to a variety of personal and financial benefits, and is an integral part of establishing a successful career path and enhancing earnings over a lifetime (Carnevale, Rose, & Cheah, 2011). However, up until recently, low expectations coupled with minimal opportunities have prevented people with intellectual disabilities (ID) from receiving these benefits. Reauthorization of the Higher Education Act in 2008 contained several new provisions aimed at increasing access to higher education for youth and adults with ID. To address these provisions, Congress appropriated \$10.6 million for creation of a new model demonstration program via the Office of Postsecondary Education (OPE) (Duncan, 2010).

In 2010, the Office of Postsecondary Education (OPE) awarded grants to 27 institutes of higher education (IHEs) to fund model demonstration projects. These are referred to as Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSIDs). The goal of the TPSID program is to create, expand, or enhance high-quality, inclusive higher education experiences to support positive outcomes for individuals with ID.

The OPE also awarded a TPSID National Coordinating Center (NCC) grant to the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston. Among the responsibilities of the TPSID NCC was the development of a valid and reliable evaluation framework for the TPSID programs. This report provides a summary of the creation of this evaluation framework and a comprehensive look at critical components of the TPSID programs throughout the US in the 2010–2011 academic year.

The report describes the types of IHEs that received TPSID grants, characteristics of attending students, and detailed information about academic access, employment and career development, campus membership, and program elements that supported self-determination skills, such as person-centered planning. The report also details the TPSID programs' efforts at collaborating with internal and external partners, the extent to which the TPSID programs are integrated into the existing policies and practices of the college, efforts aimed at sustaining these programs, and evaluation strategies employed by the TPSID programs.



PRIMARY FINDINGS OF THIS YEAR I REPORT INCLUDE:

Demographics.

In 2010–2011, 15 TPSID programs operated on single campuses and 12 operated as consortia with satellite campuses, for a total of 27 model demonstration projects on 42 campuses. Four hundred sixty students attended TPSID programs (across 30 sites). Twelve TPSID projects were in a planning year and not serving students during Year One. Fifty-nine percent of students were male and 41% were female. The majority of students (89%) were between the ages of 19 and 28. The most commonly reported disability categories for students were intellectual disability, autism, and developmental delay. Approximately one fifth of the students (21%) were dually enrolled and were receiving transition services via their local K-12 education agency.

Academic Access.

In Year One, 394 TPSID students were enrolled in a total of 1,897 courses, an average of nearly five enrollments per student. Over half of those course enrollments (58%) were in specialized courses, i.e., courses that were only attended by TPSID students. The remaining 42% of course enrollments were in inclusive courses, i.e., attended by TPSID and non-TPSID students.

Employment.

Of the 460 students who attended TPSID programs, 124 (27%) held a total of 143 paid jobs during the first year of the program. One hundred five students held one paid job, 18 students had two paid jobs, and one student had three paid jobs. Two fifths of the students with paid jobs (44%) had never held a paid job prior to entering the TPSID program. Individual jobs accounted for more than half of the paid jobs held by students (52%), and paid internships (non-credit) accounted for 23% of the paid jobs held by students.

Self-determination.

In the first year of the program, 97% of TPSIDs reported using person-centered planning with participating students. Twenty-three percent of the TPSIDs reported using existing academic advising offices, and another 29% used both specialized and typical academic advising systems. Forty-five percent of TPSIDs ($n = 14$) had a separate advising system specially designed only for TPSID students and administered by TPSID staff.

Campus Membership.

Students participated in numerous social activities, including attending events on campus, going out with friends, and participating in clubs or student organizations. Of the 30 TPSIDs serving students in Year One, 11 provided access to housing, 10 had student housing but did not provide access to TPSID students, and nine did not offer housing to any student. Nearly three-quarters (72%) of TPSID students lived with family.

Exiting Students.

A total of 136 TPSID students exited their program in Year One. Eighty-six of these students (63%) earned a credential. Roughly one quarter of the students who exited in Year One (29%) were reported as having a paid job, participating in unpaid career development activities, or doing both at the point when they exited the TPSID program. Students who exited with paid employment on average worked 17 hours per week and earned \$8.21 per hour.

Alignment with College Systems and Practices.

The vast majority of TPSID programs followed the academic calendar used by the IHE (90%), held students to the same code of conduct as other students (97%), and issued student identification cards (97%) to TPSID students. Campus facilities and resources accessed by TPSID students included the student center/dining hall, bookstores, library, computer lab/student IT services, sports and recreational facilities, and arts/cultural center.

Coordination and Collaboration.

The 42 participating TPSID sites partnered with a total of 190 external organizations. The most common partners were local education agencies (LEAs) and vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies, with over half of the TPSID sites partnering with these organizations.

Sustainability.

IHE resources and student/family funds were the most common sources of funds (aside from the OPE grants) received by TPSIDs. Fifty-five percent of programs serving students in Year One (n=17) received funding from family and students. TPSIDs also received support from human services agencies that serve individuals with ID, including VR, LEAs, and state intellectual/developmental disability agencies. Average annual costs to students ranged from \$2,000 to \$16,000, and depended upon the type of institution (two-year or four-year) and whether the IHE charges were residency-dependent.

Evaluation.

Each TPSID, in addition to entering data into the NCC evaluation system, created its own mechanisms for self-assessment. The evaluation tools used by TPSIDs included assessment of students' academic and career interests and progress, goal attainment, and self-determination. TPSIDs regularly sought feedback from students, faculty, peer mentors, family members, TPSID staff, and employers of TPSID students via interviews and meetings.

This Year One TPSID Annual Report demonstrates that given the opportunity, the charge, and sufficient funding, institutions of higher education can partner effectively with LEAs as well as state and regional agencies to serve students with an intellectual disability. The TPSID programs described here have provided an unprecedented opportunity for 460 students with ID to access college courses, participate in internships and integrated competitive employment, and engage in the same social and personal development activities that other college students enjoy throughout the country.

While a significant amount of progress is evident, the report reflects remaining barriers as well. Achievement of program goals related to inclusive course access and attainment of paid integrated employment and meaningful credentials will take additional and sustained efforts on the part of those implementing the TPSID programs.



EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Higher education leads to a variety of personal and financial benefits, and is an integral part of establishing a successful career path and enhancing earnings over a lifetime (Carnevale, Rose, & Cheah, 2011). However, up until recently, low expectations coupled with minimal opportunities have prevented people with intellectual disabilities (ID) from receiving these benefits. Reauthorization of the Higher Education Act in 2008 contained several new provisions aimed at increasing access to higher education for youth and adults with ID. To address these provisions, Congress appropriated \$10.6 million for creation of a new model demonstration program via the Office of Postsecondary Education (OPE) (Duncan, 2010).

In 2010, the Office of Postsecondary Education (OPE) awarded grants to 27 institutes of higher education (IHEs) to fund model demonstration projects. These are referred to as Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSIDs). The goal of the TPSID program is to create, expand, or enhance high-quality, inclusive higher education experiences to support positive outcomes for individuals with ID.

The OPE also awarded a TPSID National Coordinating Center (NCC) grant to the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston. Among the responsibilities of the TPSID NCC was the development of a valid and reliable evaluation framework for the TPSID programs. This Year Two Report provides a summary of the creation of this evaluation framework and a comprehensive look at critical components of the TPSID programs throughout the U.S. in the 2011–2012 academic year, which was the second year the program was funded.

The report describes the types of colleges that received TPSID grants, characteristics of attending students, and detailed information about academic access, employment and career development, campus membership, and program elements that supported self-determination, such as person-centered planning. The report also details the TPSID programs' efforts at collaborating with internal and external partners, the extent to which the TPSID programs are integrated into the existing policies and practices of the college, efforts aimed at sustaining these programs, and evaluation strategies employed by the TPSID programs beyond those used by the NCC.



PRIMARY FINDINGS OF THIS YEAR TWO REPORT INCLUDE:

Demographics.

In 2011–2012, 16 TPSID programs operated on single campuses and 11 operated as consortia with satellite campuses, for a total of 27 model demonstration projects on 43 campuses in 23 states. During Year Two, there were a total of 792 students who attended TPSID programs (across 42 sites). Of those students, 318 students also attended the program in Year One, while 474 were new students. One TPSID project site was in a planning year and not serving students while 42 campuses served students during Year Two. Male students were more prevalent (59%) than were female students (41%). Most students (90%) were between the ages of 18 and 28. The most frequently reported disability categories for students were intellectual disability, autism, and developmental delay. Close to one quarter of the students (24%) were dually enrolled and were receiving transition services via their local K-12 education agency.

Academic Access.

In Year Two, 663 TPSID students were enrolled in a total of 4,806 courses, an average of just over 7 course enrollments per student. Over half of those course enrollments (53%) were in specialized courses, i.e., courses that were specifically designed for and only attended by TPSID students. The remaining 47% of course enrollments were in inclusive courses, i.e., attended by TPSID and typical college (non-TPSID) students.

Career Development and Employment.

Of the 792 TPSID students who attended TPSID programs during Year Two, 236 (30%) held a total of 304 paid jobs. Seventy-four of these jobs (24%) were ones that students had also worked in during Year One. Of students who were employed, 168 students held one paid job, 59 students had two paid jobs, and 9 students had 3 paid jobs. Additionally, 45% of employed students had never held a paid job prior to entering the TPSID program. Individual jobs accounted for more than half of the paid jobs held by students (57%), and paid internships (non-credit) accounted for 18% of the paid jobs held by students. Eighty-two percent of the students who held jobs were paid at or above minimum wage, 11% paid less than minimum wage, and wage status was unknown for the remaining 8% of jobs.

Self-determination.

The majority of the TPSIDs (93%) reported using person-centered planning with participating students. Twelve percent of the TPSIDs reported using existing academic advising offices, and another 37% used both specialized and typical academic advising systems. Forty-four percent of TPSIDs ($N = 19$) had a separate advising system specially designed only for TPSID students and administered by TPSID staff.

Campus Membership.

Students participated in a wide range of formal and informal social activities, including attending events on campus ($n=490$), going out with friends ($n=513$), and participating in clubs or student organizations ($n=317$). Of the 42 TPSIDs serving students in Year Two, 12 provided access to housing, 6 had student housing but did not provide access to TPSID students and 24 did not offer housing to any student. The majority of TPSID students (64%) lived with family.

Exiting Students.

A total of 304 TPSID students exited their program in Year Two. Of these, 163 students (54%) earned a credential upon exit. Roughly one-half of the students who exited in Year Two (48%) were reported as having a paid job, participating in unpaid career development activities, or doing both at the point when they exited the TPSID program. Students who exited with paid employment on average worked 18 hours per week and earned \$7.89 per hour.

Alignment with College Systems and Practices.

The majority of TPSID programs followed the academic calendar used by the IHE (95%), held students to the same code of conduct as other students (98%) and issued TPSID students college ID cards. Almost two-thirds of TPSIDs also issued TPSID students a college transcript. Campus facilities and resources accessed by TPSID students included the student center/dining hall, bookstores, library, computer lab/student IT services, and sports and recreational facilities or arts/cultural center.

Coordination and Collaboration.

The 43 participating TPSID sites partnered with a total of 187 external organizations. The most common partners were local education agencies and vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies, with over half of the TPSID sites partnering with these organizations.

Sustainability.

IHE resources and student/family funds were the most common sources of funds (aside from the federal grant funds) received by TPSIDs. Forty-percent of programs serving students in Year Two (n=17) received funding from family and students. TPSIDs also received support from human services agencies that serve individuals with ID, including Vocational Rehabilitation, Local Education Agency, and state Intellectual /Developmental Disability agencies. Average annual costs to students ranged from \$2,000 to \$16,000 and depended upon the type of institution (2 or 4 year), and whether the IHE charges were residency dependent.

Evaluation.

Each TPSID in addition to entering data into the NCC evaluation system used various other mechanisms for self-assessment. The evaluation tools being used by TPSIDs included assessment of students' academic and career interests and progress, goal attainment, and assessments of students' self-determination. TPSIDs regularly sought feedback from students, faculty, peer mentors, family members, TPSID staff, and employers of TPSID students via interviews and meetings.

This Year Two Annual Report on the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID) Model Demonstration Projects reflects continued growth of higher education options. The development of new consortia partners as well as expanded access to inclusive courses and integrated paid employment for TPSID students demonstrate some of the potential outcomes of partnerships between institutes of higher education and LEA and state and regional agencies. The TPSID programs described here have provided an unprecedented opportunity for 792 students to access college courses, participate in internships and integrated competitive employment, and engage in the same social and personal development activities that other college students enjoy throughout the country. While this report reflects progress, it also reflects that the long-term goals of the TPSID program have yet to be fully attained. Continued efforts must focus on expanded inclusive course access, increased credential attainment, as well as an increase in the number of students with ID who achieve integrated competitive employment along with an increase in the number of hours worked weekly especially upon exiting the TPSID program.